Some art is meant to be touched.

We walked through teamLab in Tokyo, knee-deep in lit water, and wondered who gets left outside.



MONA LISA · HER FIGURE · 40 OF 100 BALLS RAISED

THE VISITOR HEARS

A voice guide tours a famous painting, part by part.

THE VISITOR FEELS

A 10×10 board of balls raises the shape of the part being described.

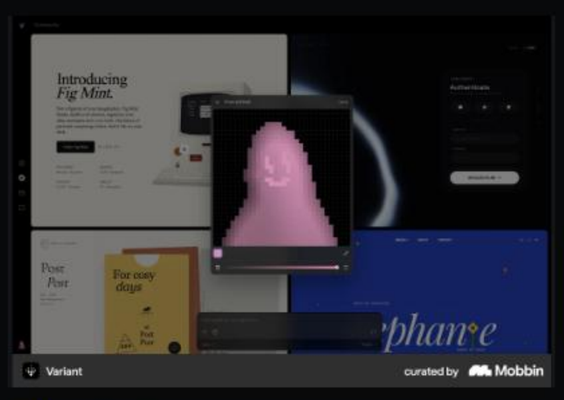
THE ROOM SEES

This screen: what the visitor hears and feels, live, for everyone watching.

RESEARCH · MOBBIN, 9 SECTIONS

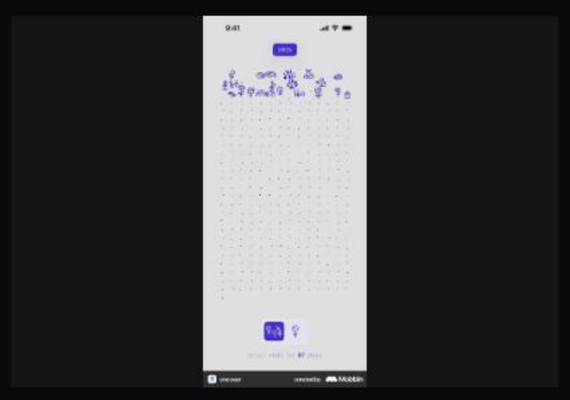
147 screens, 24 that shaped it.

For each one we wrote down what to take and what to leave. These are the ones we took the most from.



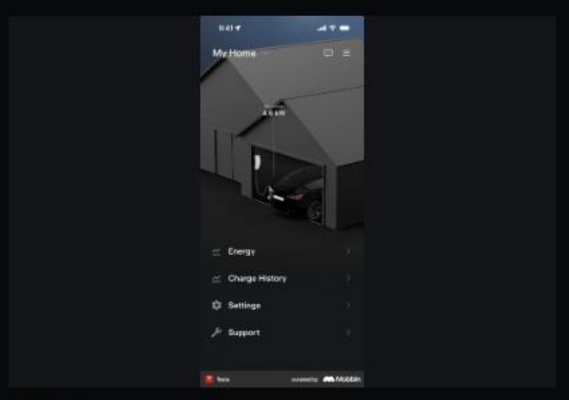
B05 VARIANT

Coarse pixel grids still read as pictures.



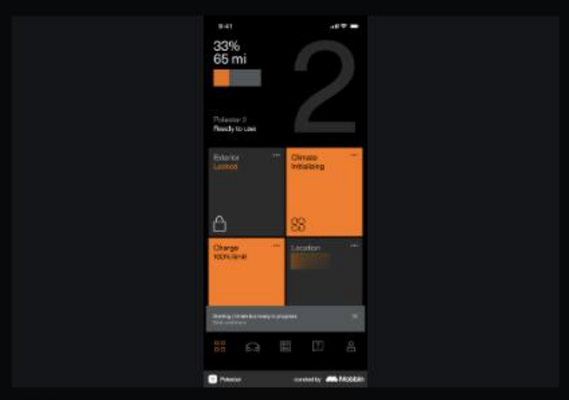
B15 ONE YEAR

A grid of dots with hand-drawn flowers on top.



B19 TESLA

Label the live value on the object itself.



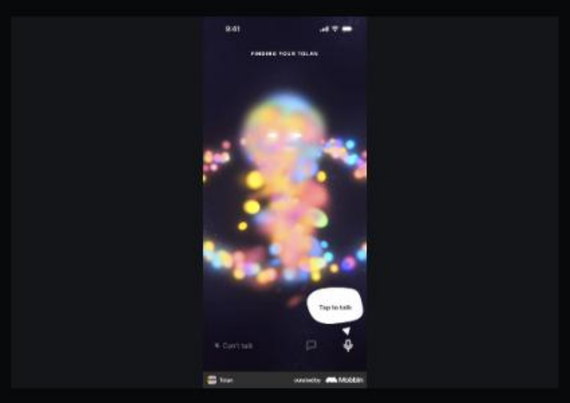
B20 POLESTAR

One huge numeral says where you are.



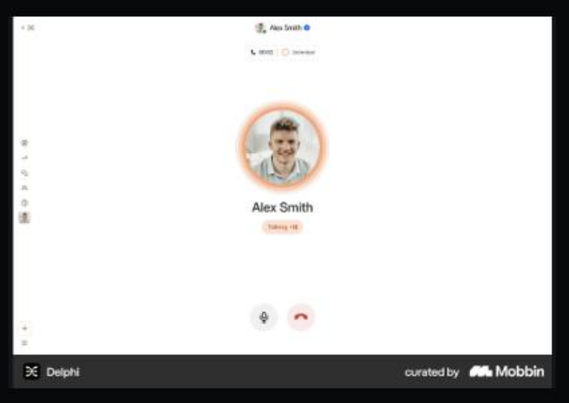
C10 MINDTRIP

Say who is speaking, in words.



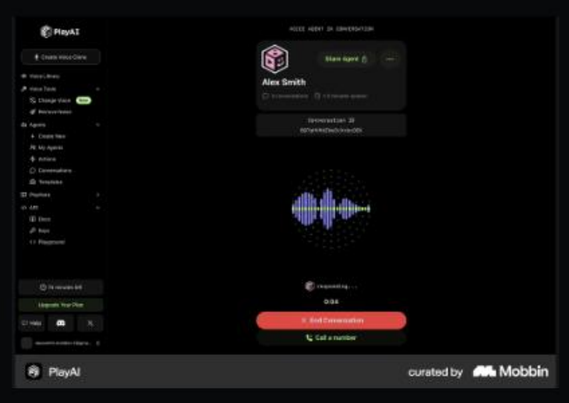
C11 TOLAN

Light on darkness, like a teamLab room.



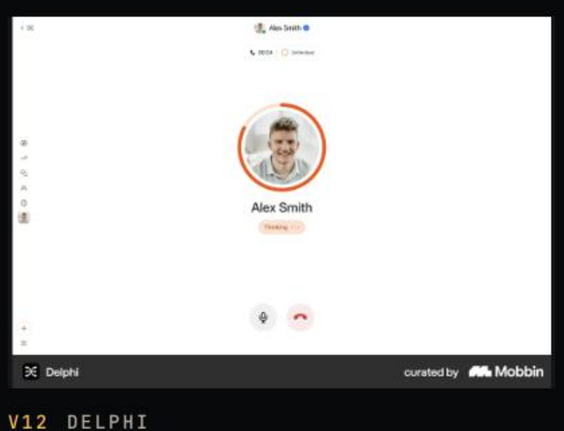
V01 DELPHI

Ripples mean someone is talking.



V03 PLAYAI

A voice waveform drawn out of dots.



V12 DELPHI

A third state between turns: thinking.



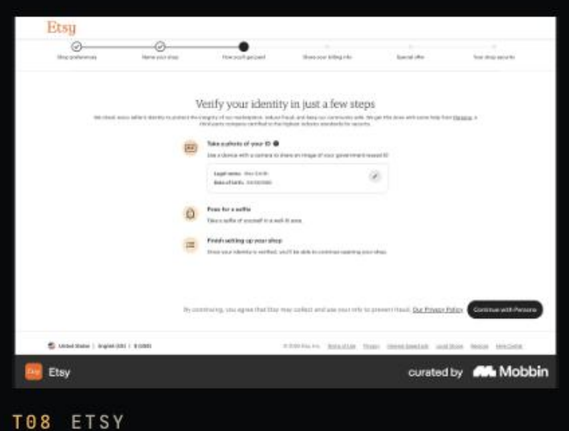
T01 GUSTO

Solid rail for done, dotted for still to come.



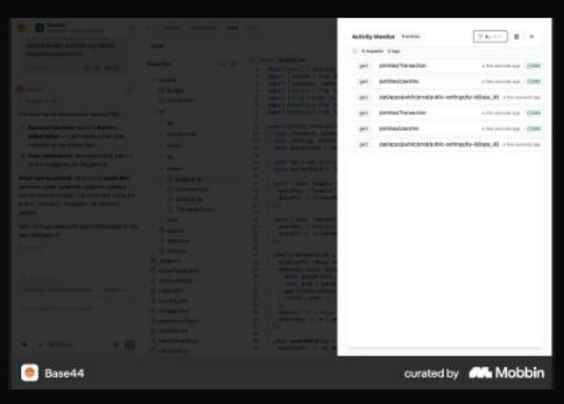
T03 HERS

Serif numerals and hairline rules.



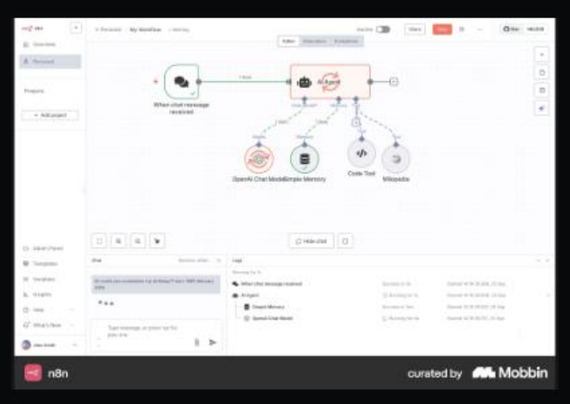
T08 ETSY

Big dot for now, small dots for later.



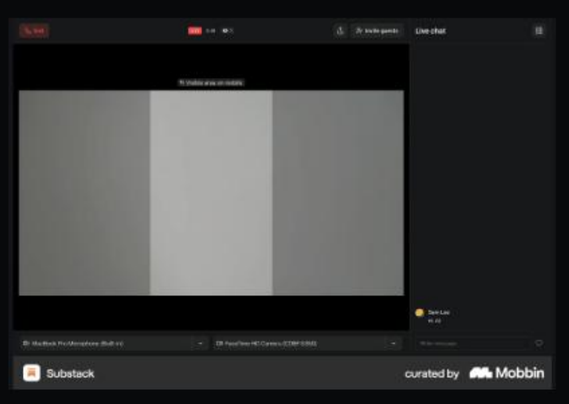
A07 BASE44

A drawer that never reflows the page.



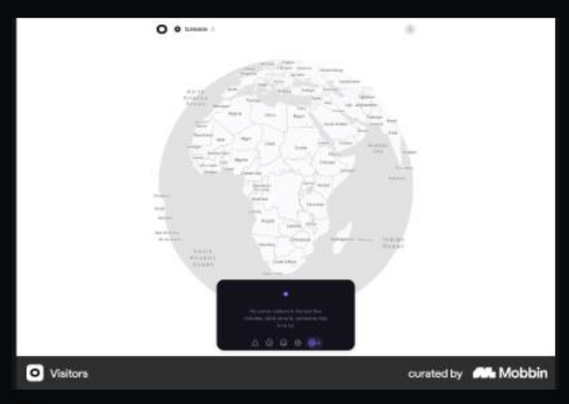
A12 N8N

Show which step of the pipeline is live.



H04 SUBSTACK

A compact LIVE 0:38 tag is enough.



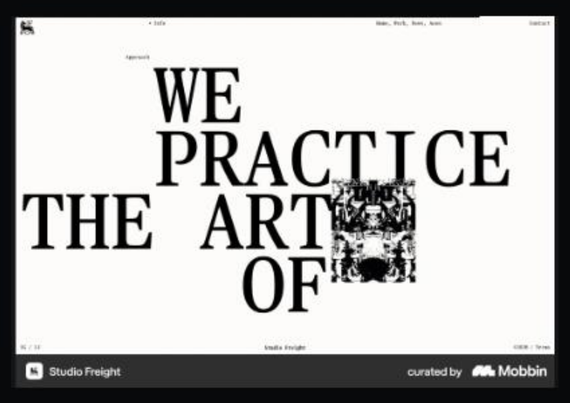
H10 VISITORS

Warm words for an empty room.



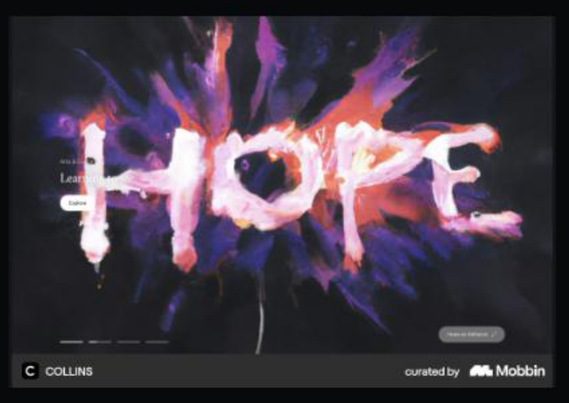
I03 HARVEST

Kicker, title, byline: a wall label.



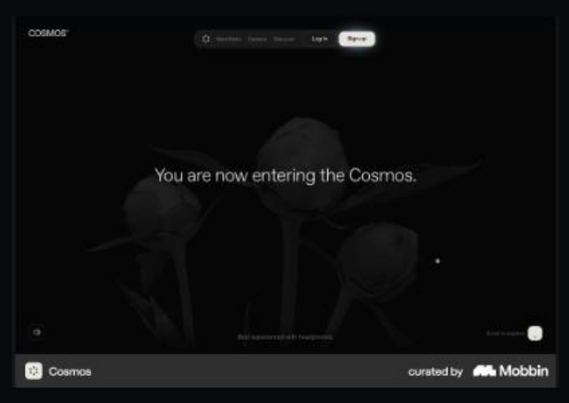
I07 STUDIO FREIGHT

Huge type next to tiny mono labels.



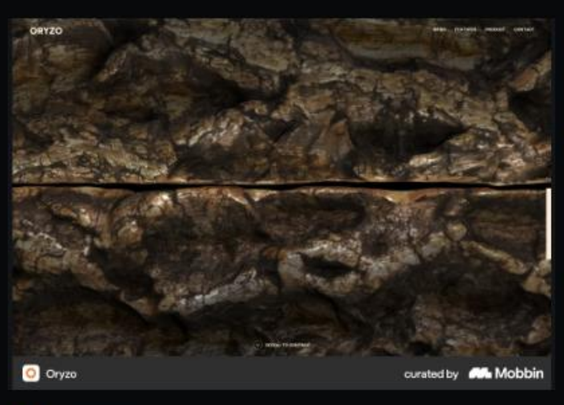
I09 COLLINS

“Learning to see.” The right tone.



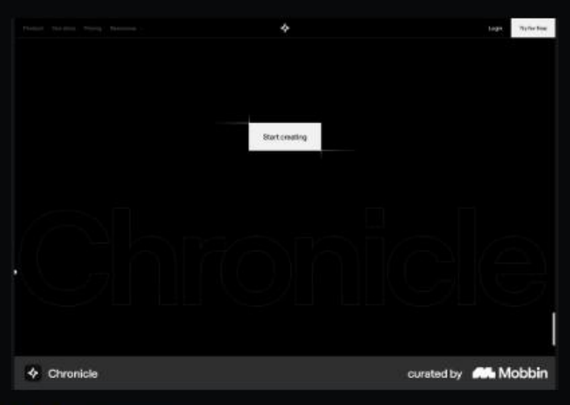
I15 COSMOS

Darkness, faint flowers, one quiet line.



I22 ORYZO

Raking light makes a surface feel touchable.



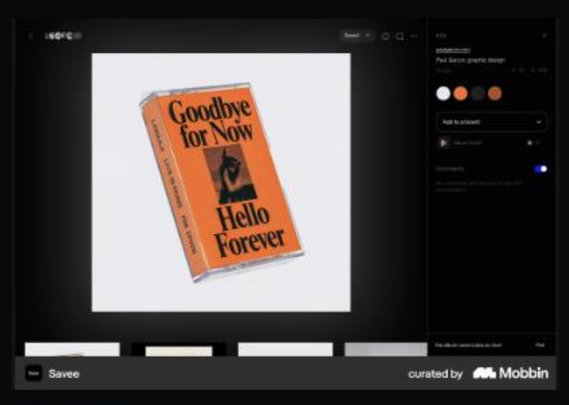
I26 CHRONICLE

A hairline outline as the backdrop.



I28 COSMOS

Tactile objects around a serif headline.



P03 SAVEE

The interface takes the artwork’s colours.

SEVEN PATTERNS KEPT COMING BACK

1 Darkness, with light as the material.

2 Serif display with mono labels: a museum placard.

3 Dots as the shared language, because the board is made of balls.

4 A huge numeral answers “where am I?”

5 Hand-made marks beat the generic look.

6 The interface takes its colour from the art.

7 Avoid blue-purple gradients, glowing orbs, log tables and stacks of cards.

THREE DIRECTIONS

A · Borderless Night

CHOSEN

One dark gallery room where light is the hierarchy, and the painting flows into the board like teamLab art moving between rooms.

Strongest link to our story. Risk: dark screens wash out on cheap projectors, so text stays at AAA contrast.

B · Wall Label

Light museum walls, black serif, catalogue numbering. Very legible, less immersive. We kept its type discipline.

C · Pin Art

The hardware as a 3D hero in raking light. Great for the board, but kitsch risk, and the painting loses the spotlight.

DESIGN SYSTEM · COLOUR

Lantern Water

The water room at teamLab Planets, lit by lanterns. Every colour is an object you could point at in that room.



`--color-ink`

#08090B

black water · page



`--color-stone`

#131518

wet stone · drawer



`--color-stone-2`

#1C1F23

stone edge · hairlines, wells



`--color-paper`

#F2EADC · 16.7:1

lantern paper · text



`--color-paper-dim`

#B4AB9C · 8.8:1

paper in shadow · secondary



`--color-paper-faint`

#7E776D · 4.5:1

decoration only



`--color-lantern`

#FFB547 · 11.3:1

lantern flame · the one accent, it means "now"



`--color-moss`

#8CC48A · 9.8:1

moss · DONE



`--color-koi`

#FF6B4A · 7.1:1

koi · FAILED

THREE RULES

One intense colour moment: lantern means now.

Status is never colour alone; it always has a word.

Raised balls take the colour of the painting under them.

DESIGN SYSTEM · TYPE

A museum wall label

Instrument Serif speaks, Instrument Sans explains, JetBrains Mono labels. Huge and light next to small and crisp. Nothing below 13px.

--text-numeral
Serif · 360 / 270 px · outline
Part number behind the board

02

--text-display
Serif · 80 / 60 px · -0.02em
Painting title, idle headline

Mona Lisa

--text-title
Serif · 48 / 36 px
The part being touched

her eyes

--text-kicker
Serif italic · 28 / 22 px
Artist, kickers

Leonardo da Vinci

--text-caption-now
Sans 500 · 30/40 · 24/32 px
The newest spoken line

Her eyes seem to follow you across the room.

--text-body
Sans 400 · 20/30 · 17/26 px
Older lines, descriptions

Leonardo painted her without eyebrows, which makes the gaze feel softer.

--text-label
Mono 500 · 14 / 13 px · +0.14em
Labels, state words, timers

NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

SPACE · 8PX BASE

spacing-2 · 8

spacing-4 · 16

spacing-5 · 24

spacing-6 · 32

spacing-7 · 48

spacing-8 · 64

spacing-9 · 96 — gutter between art and touch

spacing-10 · 128

Columns 58 / 42. Everything scales with clamp() from 1920 down to 1440, tightens at 720p, and stacks below 1100px.

SHAPE · CIRCLES AND HAIRLINES



Circles and hairlines. Light is the only depth.

No cards, no rounded panels, no drop shadows. Every indicator on the screen is the same ball at a different size, so the room speaks the board's language.

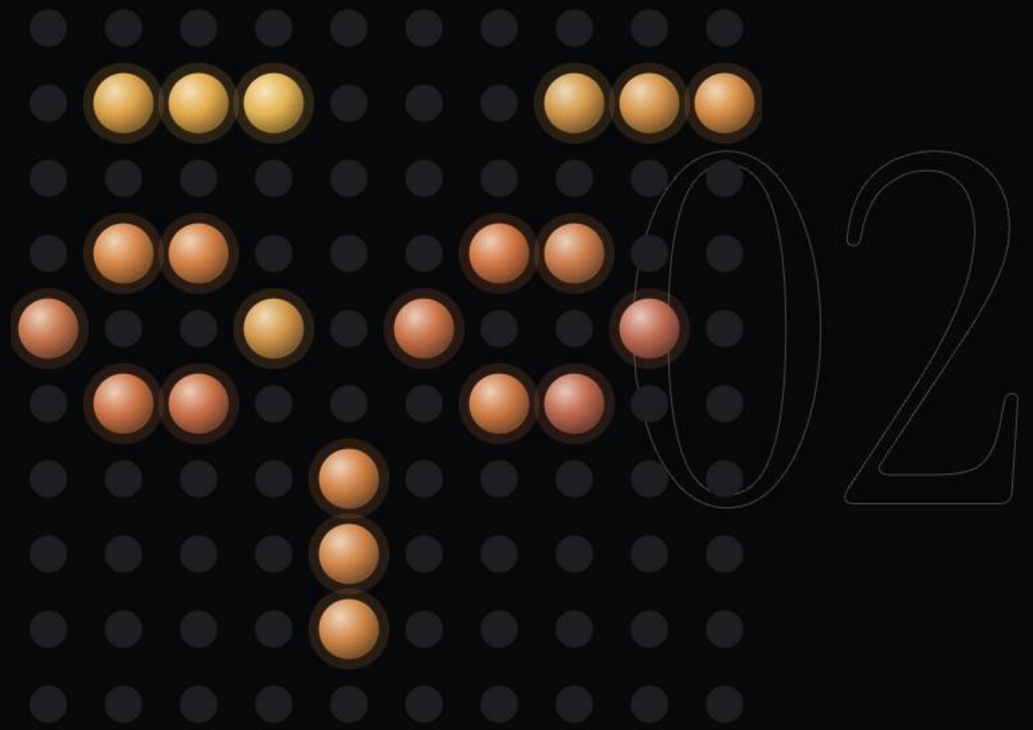
MOTION · PHYSICAL, NEVER BOUNCY UI

--ease-rise	cubic-bezier(.34,1.56,.64,1)	a ball pops up, slight overshoot
--ease-light	cubic-bezier(.22,1,.36,1)	light fades, the spotlight glides
--dur-ball + row	400ms + 70ms per row	rows rise one after another, like the hardware
--dur-spot	600ms	spotlight moves to the next part
--dur-flow	900ms	dots fly from the painting to the board
--dur-ripple	1600ms loop	speaking ripples, like water at your feet
reduced motion	200ms fades	no flying, no ripples, no sweeps

VOICE · A MUSEUM PLACARD

DO	DON'T
Now touching: her hands	Section 2 loaded
The guide is on a break.	Status: OK
Best experienced with your hands.	AI-powered experience

SIMULATED BOARD



NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

her eyes

TOP CENTER OF THE CANVAS

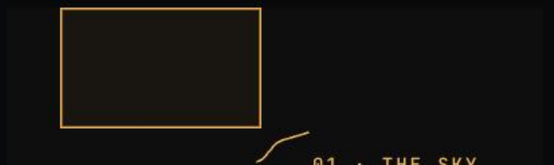
SPOTLIGHT TAG · HANGS OFF THE PART ON A HAND-DRAWN HOOK



ABOVE RIGHT · DEFAULT



ABOVE LEFT · PART AT RIGHT EDGE



BELOW RIGHT · PART AT TOP EDGE



BELOW LEFT · TOP-RIGHT CORNER

Outside the part, the painting dims to 62% ink. The edge is 1.5px lantern. The hook is one wobbly stroke drawn by hand, the only mark on the screen that isn't a circle or a straight line.

TOP STRIP

Tactile Art Guide

● LIVE 03:12 [S] AGENTS

SPEAKING INDICATOR · EIGHT DOTS ON A RING



SPEAKING
rings ripple outward



THINKING
dots orbit while Gemini works



LISTENING
a slow breath

CAPTIONS · NEWEST LARGEST, OLDER FADE

VISITOR
Show me the Mona Lisa.

GUIDE
Under your hand is her whole figure, seated, hands folded.

VISITOR
I'm ready for the next part.

GUIDE SPEAKING

Now her eyes. Leonardo painted them without eyebrows, so the gaze feels soft wherever you stand.

TOUR RAIL · VISITED, NOW, TO COME

HER FIGURE — HER EYES — HER SMILE — PATH AND BRIDGE — MISTY MOUNTAINS

Behind the scenes

[S] CLOSE

● DONE — **ElevenLabs**
Voice guide
`In conversation`

● WORKING — **Gemini**
Finds the parts, draws each shape
`Looking up The Birth of Venus`

● WAITING — **Creao**
Tactile Tour Writer agent
–

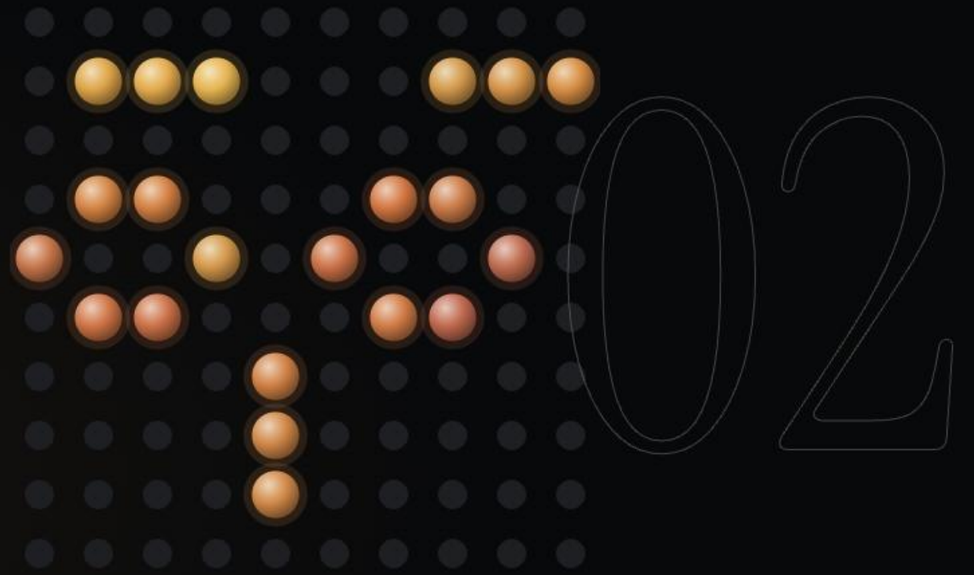
● FAILED — **Browser Use**
Reads the museum's website
`Museum site timed out`

ON THE WIRE

F0000000000011100111000000000001100110001001010010001100110000001000000000010000000000100000000000000

SIMULATED BOARD





NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

her eyes

TOP CENTER OF THE CANVAS

VISITOR

I'm ready for the next part.

GUIDE SPEAKING

Now her eyes. Leonardo painted them without eyebrows, so the gaze feels soft wherever you stand.

Leonardo da Vinci

Mona Lisa

C. 1503–1506

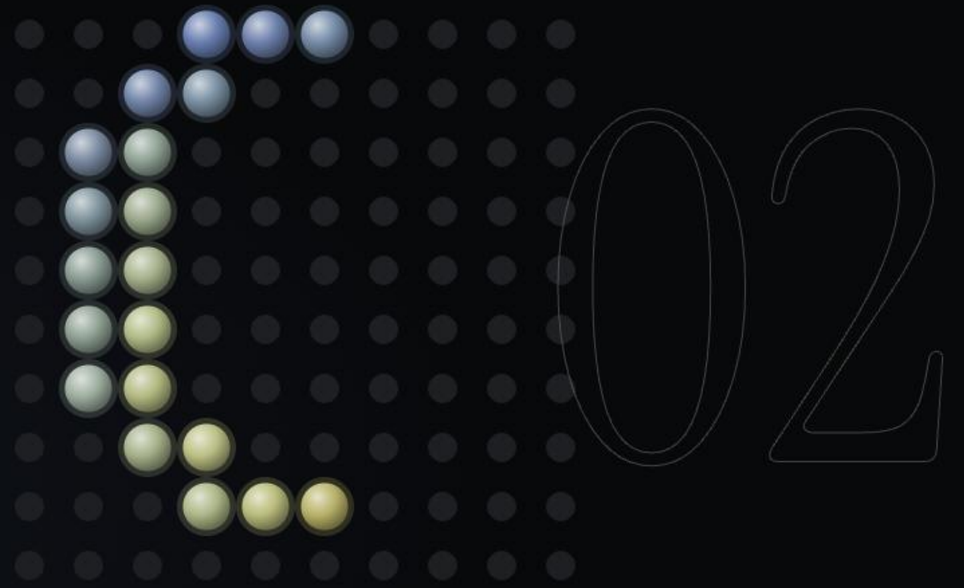


Vincent van Gogh

The Starry Night

1889

SIMULATED BOARD



NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 04

the crescent moon

TOP RIGHT OF THE CANVAS

VISITOR

What's up in the corner?

GUIDE SPEAKING

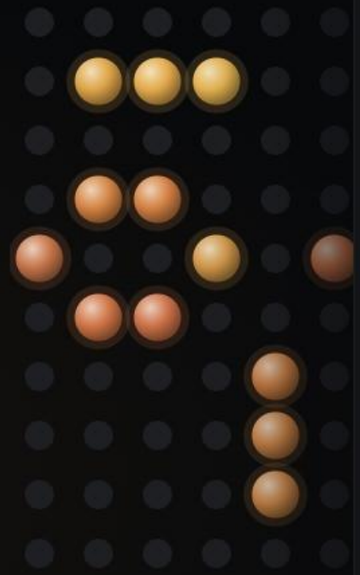
That's the crescent moon. Van Gogh wrapped it in a ring of light, so it glows hotter than any star.



Leonardo da Vinci

Mona Lisa

C. 1503–1506



NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

her eyes

TOP CENTER OF THE CANVAS

VISITOR

I'm ready for the next part.

GUIDE SPEAKING

Now her eyes. Leo
eyebrows, so the g
stand.

Behind the scenes

S CLOSE

WORKING — **ElevenLabs**
Voice guide
`show_section("next") → her eyes`

DONE — **Gemini**
Finds the parts, draws each shape
`5 parts found · 5 shapes drawn`

WORKING — **Creao**
Tactile Tour Writer agent
`Writing guide notes for her eyes`

DONE — **Browser Use**
Reads the museum's website
`3 facts from louvre.fr`

ON THE WIRE

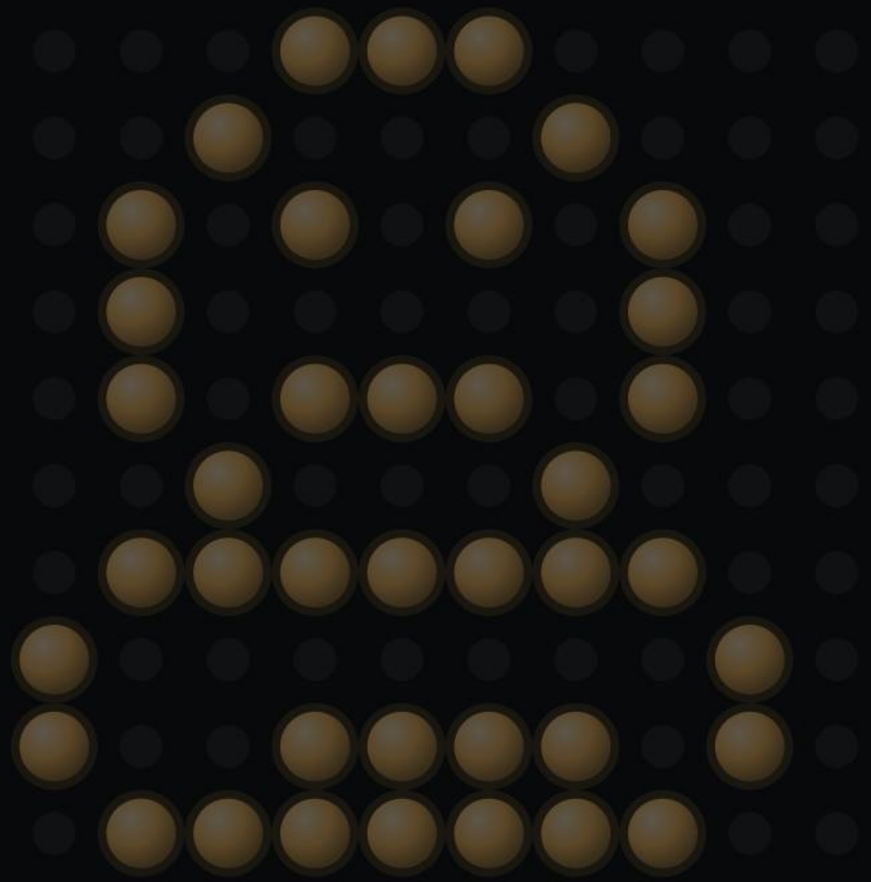
F0000000000011100011100000000000110001100100101001001100011000000100000000010000000001000000000000000



Mona Lisa · her figure

Some art is meant to be touched.

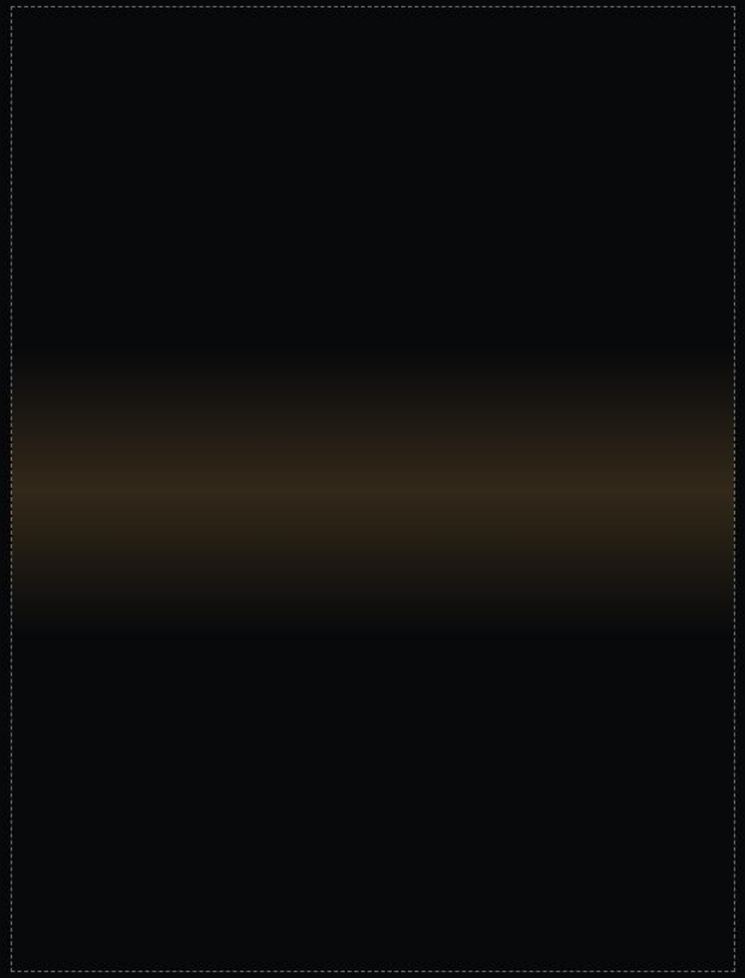
SAY “SHOW ME THE MONA LISA”



The gallery is closed

The guide is on a break.

START MAIN.PY TO OPEN THE GALLERY.



FINDING THE PARTS OF THE PAINTING

Looking up The Birth of Venus

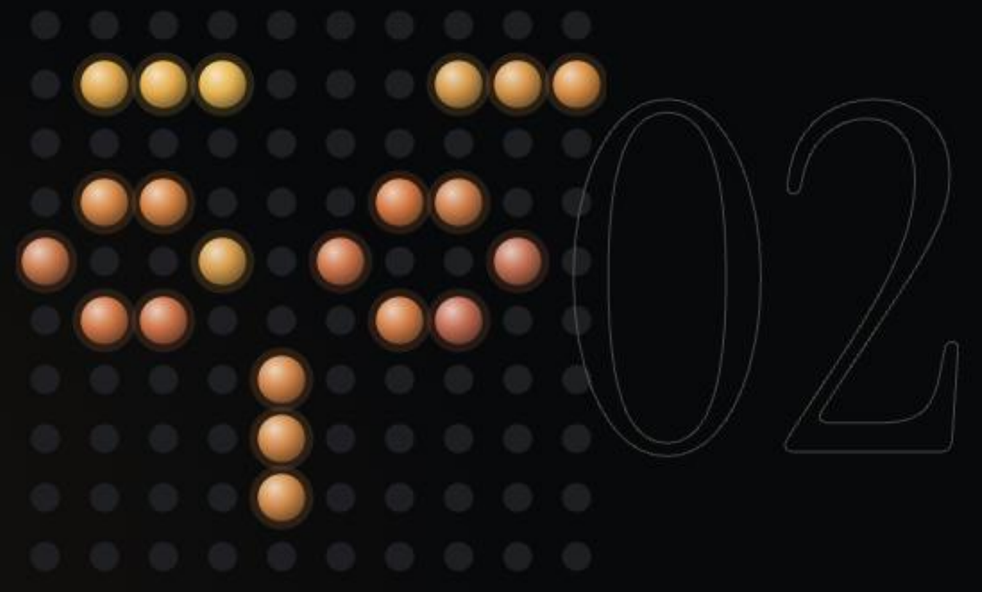


Leonardo da Vinci

Mona Lisa

C. 1503-1506

SIMULATED BOARD



NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

her eyes

TOP CENTER OF THE CANVAS

VISITOR

I'm ready for the next part.

GUIDE SPEAKING

Now her eyes. Leonardo painted them without eyebrows, so the gaze feels soft wherever you stand.

Tactile Art Guide

● LIVE 03:12 [S] AGENTS



Leonardo da Vinci

Mona Lisa

C. 1503-1506

SIMULATED BOARD

NOW TOUCHING · 02 / 05

her eyes

TOP CENTER OF THE CANVAS

VISITOR

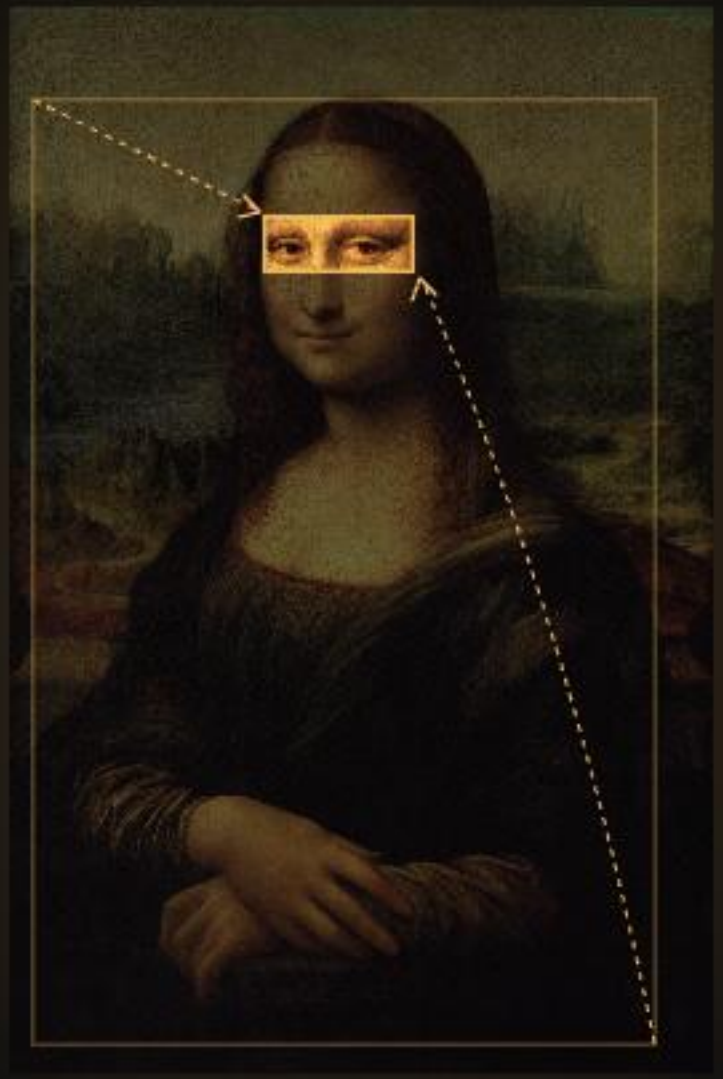
I'm ready for the next part.

GUIDE SPEAKING

Now her eyes. Leonardo painted them without eyebrows, so the gaze feels soft wherever you stand.

- HER FIGURE
- HER EYES
- HER ENIGMATIC SMILE
- THE WINDING PATH AND BRIDGE
- THE MISTY MOUNTAINS

01 # Spotlight glides

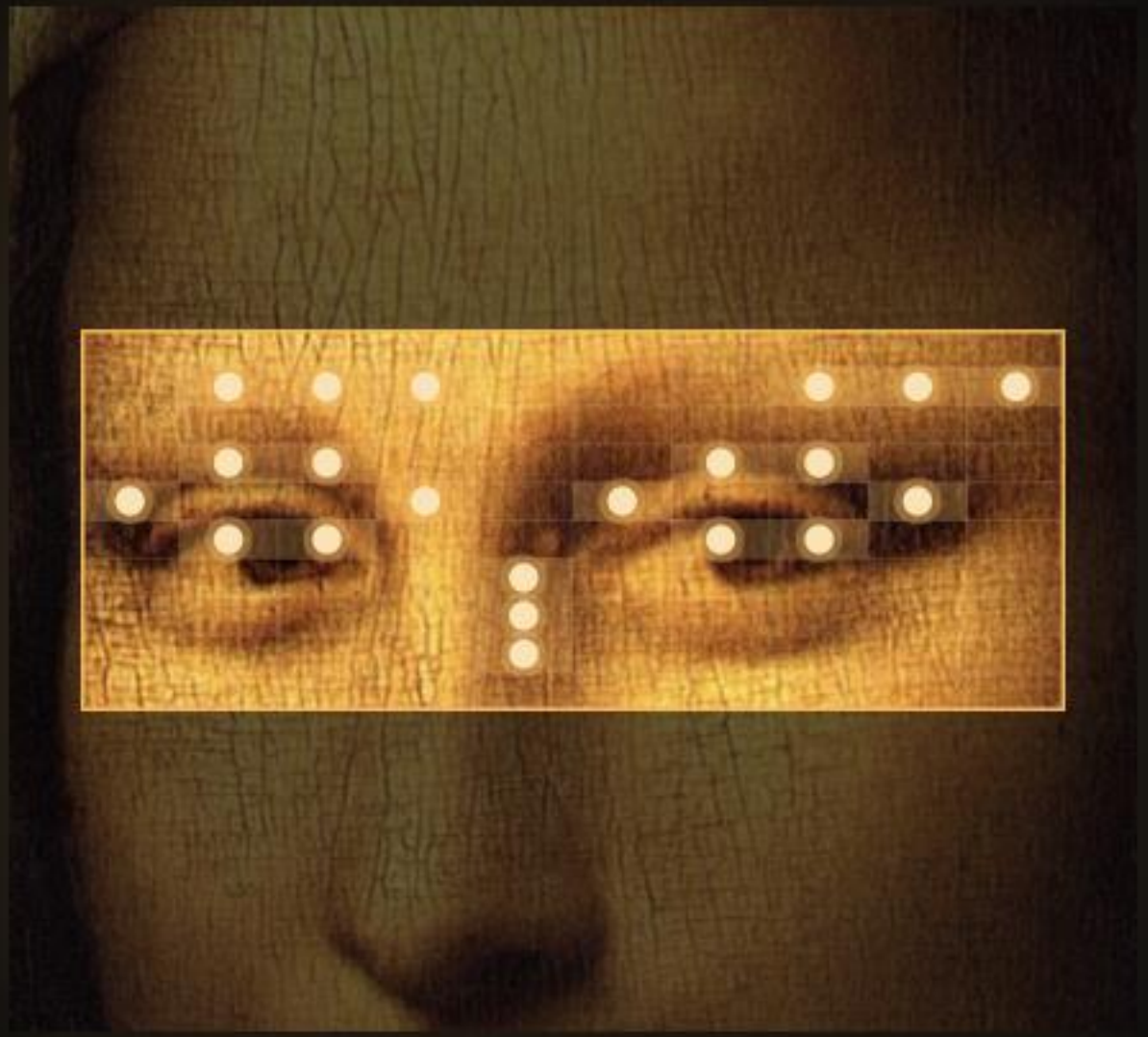


0–600 MS

The spotlight shrinks from her figure to her eyes. The old box fades out; the board waits, all balls down.

02

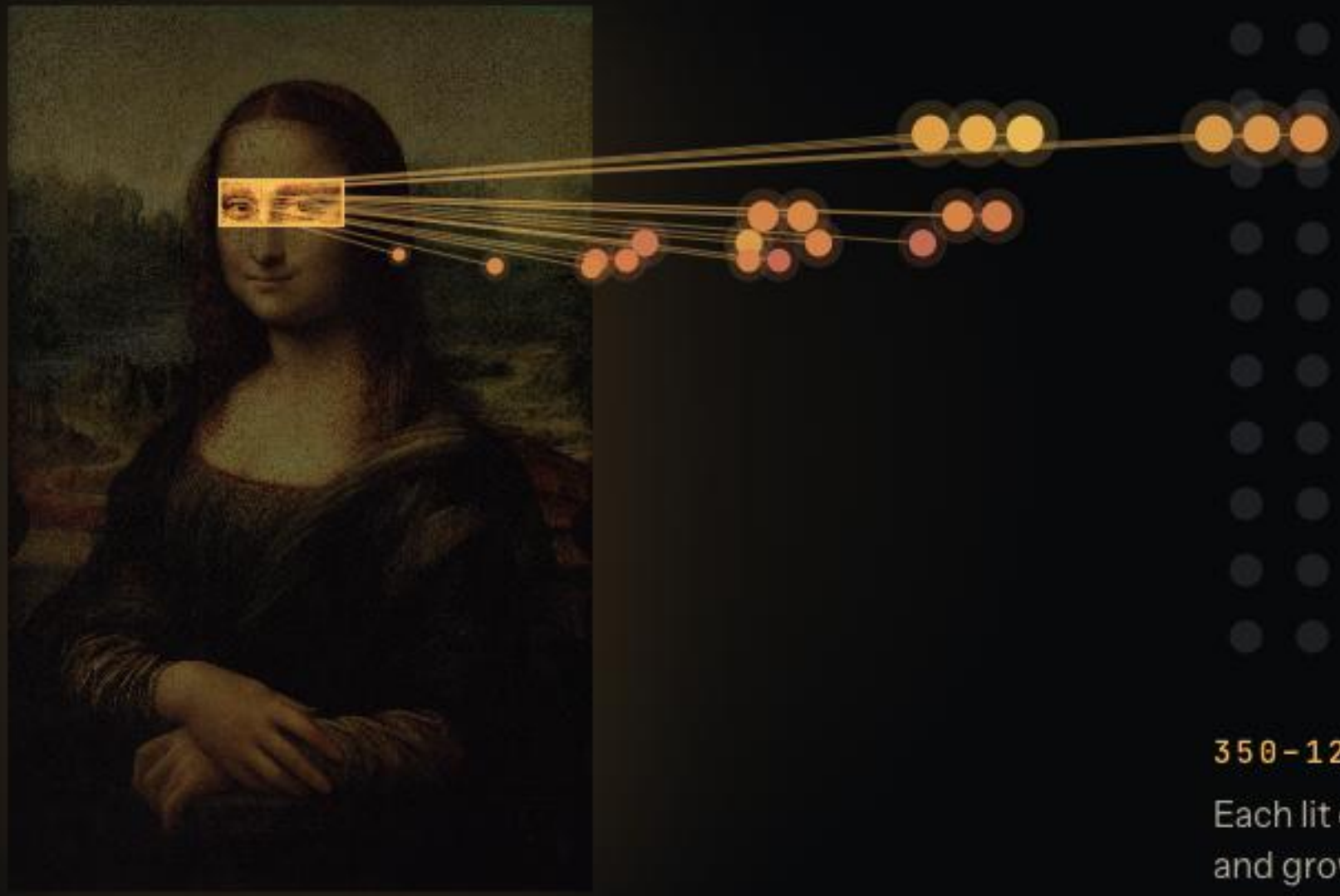
The part lights up



0–350 MS

A faint 10×10 grid lands on the box, and the cells the board will raise glow lantern. Detail view, enlarged.

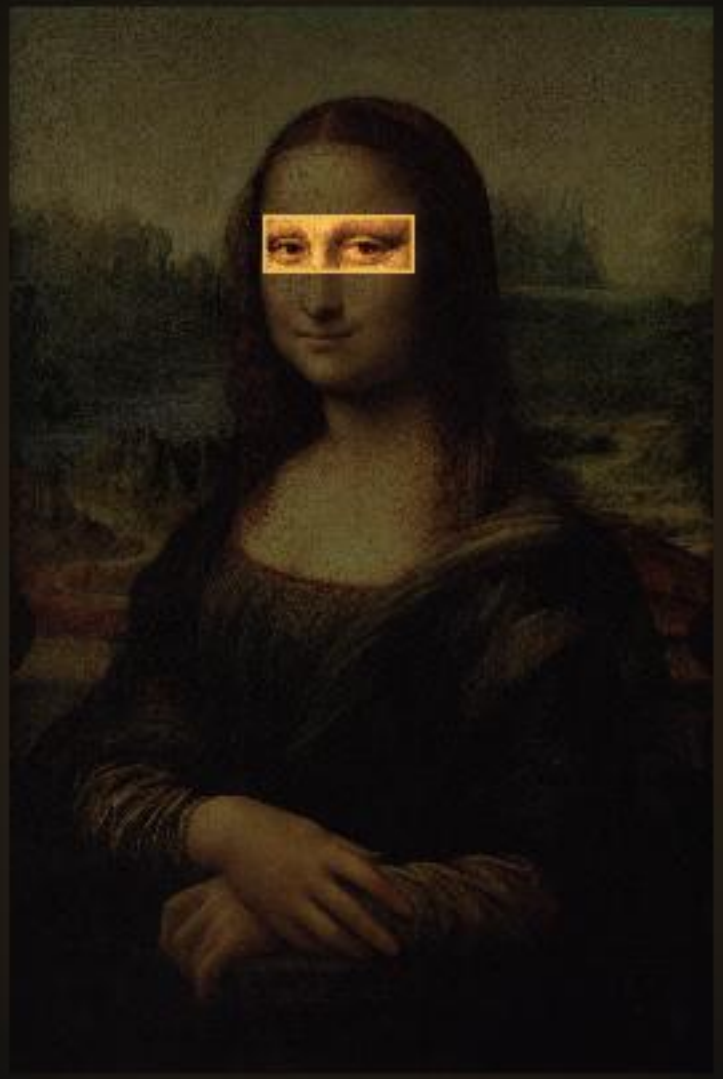
03 Dots fly

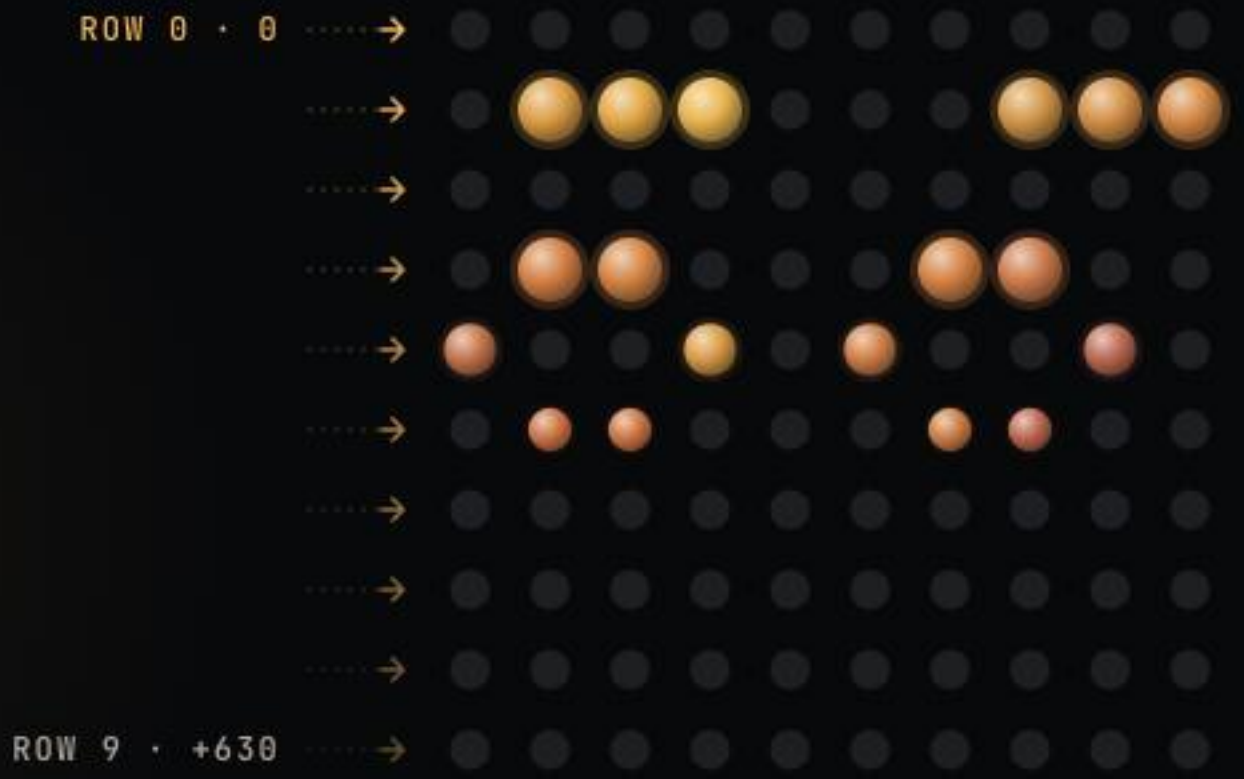


350–1250 MS

Each lit cell lifts off in the painting's colour and grows as it crosses the room to its well on the board.

04 Balls rise





+70 MS PER ROW

The balls rise in the painting's colours, top row first, so the shape draws itself from the far edge toward your hands.